Brick by Brick

The Secret to Gaining Your Competitive Edge, Building Your Credibility, or Spreading the Word about Your Company.

BY HERBERT LUI

Introduction

It is possible for you to get on any web publication. I'm not exaggerating; I'm a 20-year-old business student who has been published in on websites with national reach. If I can do it, so can you.

There are tons of perks to getting published. It ranges from building your credibility within the community of your choosing, to gaining exposure for your business, to landing freelance writing gigs for additional income in the future. That's the tip of the iceberg, but those are the reasons I've heard most.

Some other benefits include:

- Generating inbound sales leads.
- Free stuff in general. My cousin, who started writing reviews for computer hardware, would get exclusive samples from companies every week. I've gotten free invitations and media passes to conferences and networking events that I would not have had access to as a student.

Even other people become a lot friendlier when they recognize you as part of the press. You can end up having conversations with people that you thought were out of your weight class. I've had the opportunity to chat with people like Autodesk's Carl Bass, European architect Winy Maas, and new media mogul Arianna Huffington.

Why does new media in particular work so well with building your credibility and developing your reputation?

Before I answer that, I'd like to illustrate the power of getting featured.

I indulge in hip-hop sometimes, so I beg those unfamiliar with this musical allusion to bear with me…

Drake feat. Kanye West, Lil' Wayne, & Eminem

That's like Skid Row feat. Aerosmith, Bon Jovi, & Guns & Roses.

Or Jefferson Airplane feat. The Beatles, The Rolling Stones, and Stevie Wonder. (Okay, to be honest, I just Googled the term *insignificant band from the 60s*. I have no idea who Jefferson Airplane is. No disrespect meant in any case. Sorry, generational gap.)

I remember when I first saw this artist line-up, I did a double-take. At the time, Drake was a relatively amateur rapper compared to these musical veterans: What was he doing on the track with these guys?

My perception of his value and his role in the rap ecosystem changed after hearing

him perform with these rap titans on this track titled “Forever”.

Getting featured is kind of like that.

The music industry is similar to journalism in that there are tons of artists attempting to use the internet to get the attention of audiences in each sphere. Floods of amateur artists impulsively and erratically push out mixtapes, vlogs, and blog posts in an attempt to connect directly with potential listeners.

Similarly, in these days where any Joe or Jane with an idea can become a writer when they start a WordPress blog, a reputation matters more than ever in helping set yourself apart. When you get featured, this means that someone besides you thinks your thoughts matter enough to have you featured on their property online. In essence, someone is vouching for your work and your ability as a thinker.

Whether you’re someone looking to enhance his thought leadership and reputation, an aspiring writer, or an entrepreneur wanting to get validation for her idea, getting featured can help you build the reputation you want, brick by brick.

Why New Media?

Firstly, new media moves fast. You will either get published or rejected, but you will know very quickly from the editor which verdict it is. This leaves you free to react much more quickly as well, and achieve more results in a given amount of time than if you’d tried to spread your message through traditional print.

New media editors are also generally more open-minded; they’re not restricted to old school editorial policies or bureaucracy.

Lastly, a new media website of 10,000 readers will usually have a more diverse reach than a local newspaper of 10,000 readers. You will reach more people in many different social networks through new media.

Who Am I?

My name is Herbert Lui, and I'm an explorer of the intersection between art and technology. I am extremely passionate about writing; as a result, I've been blogging for five years. It has been fun.

With that said, I found that I learned a lot along the way that can accelerate other people's growth. You don't need to get caught up in your journey with the same mistakes that I made, so you've got a head start already

Here are a few sites I'm very privileged to have been published on:

- Techvibes
- Kinowear
- BetaKit
- QuickOnlineTips
- Hypebeast

They range from tech and business publications, to self-development pieces, to fashion and culture blogs; some exist as hybrids of these niches.

I'm not an internet marketing "guru", nor have I majored in Journalism or English Literature. (My formal education is in Consumer Behavior.) I've picked up most of my skills from writing for the web and attempting to build my own reputation.

What I do offer with this eBook is a concrete set of tactics to get featured on any website you can imagine. Some may take more time than others, but you will make it eventually. Consistency is key; you will build your reputation one brick at a time.

Put on your metaphorical overalls and plaid shirt.

Now, let's get started.

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I. Guest Posting 101

A journalist I once cold e-mailed once told me, "Always be pitching." While I suspect that this may have been J-school 101, this crucial idea was essential to whatever results I've achieved today. Whether you're an entrepreneur looking to get your startup out there, a blogger trying to gain exposure, or a student shooting for a publication, always be pitching.

I am not being hypothetical. As we're starting off, let's aim for five e-mails per week.

E-mail Hunting

Your access to a publication starts with sending an e-mail to the editor or administrator. How do you find their e-mail address?

I have a friend in business development who gets drunk and finds e-mail addresses. The volume that he needs to look for can be overwhelming (we're talking hundreds of e-mails per week, and a unique address and contact name for each one of those e-mails).

While I'm not advocating alcoholism, you get the idea: often times, it's pretty machine-like work, so you can be in whatever state you want. I'd advise on drinking and hunting for e-mails over drinking and a night of TV. Should you adopt this method, make sure you **do not** write your e-mail immediately after collecting this person's e-mail address until you've sobered up.

It helps to find these e-mails in batches; so you look for e-mail addresses of editors from any publication you want to get into.

Ken Lyons from WordStream has an excellent method of finding any e-mail address. Similarly, my friend Peter Sum also shares very concrete instructions how to find e-mail addresses. My personal favourites are the Google trick and the WHOIS technique. Those are mint and come in pretty handy. I'll briefly walk you through them in case you are reading this eBook offline...

The Google Trick

Here's the Google trick: Type **@domainname.com* into the search box. So if I'm searching for someone from a blog called Atlantic City (with a hypothetical domain name of http://atlanticcity.com), I would type in **@atlanticcity.com*. Usually, you want to keep your eyes peeled for search results that are press releases or Tweets. Should you stumble upon an actual e-mail address, you will now know how this particular organization or blog formats their e-mail addresses. Then, all you need is the first and last name of the editor, administrator, or blogger you're trying to contact, and you're golden.

For example, if the administrator or editor of Atlantic City is named Nucky

Thompson, and you find an e-mail address that says *al.capone@atlanticcity.com*, then you'll most likely be able to reach Nucky at *nucky.thompson@atlanticcity.com*. (With that said, you may also want to try for aliases. In this case, Nucky may be using a name like *enoch.thompson@atlanticcity.com*. Jonathan may be *jon@atlanticcity.com*. Bill may be *william@atlanticcity.com*).

If you're not sure, send one and keep your eyes peeled for a bounce back. There's also a tool called Rapportive that can confirm whether or not your e-mail address is correct by displaying a person's social media feeds that they connected to that e-mail address.

In any case, if you're not sure, just send an e-mail anyway and keep your eyes peeled for a bounceback.

WHOIS Technique

The WHOIS technique is pretty simple as well: Many new media entrepreneurs and bloggers purchase their own domain names, so what ends up happening is their contact information can be found in a WHOIS database. So if I was trying to find Nucky's e-mail address from Atlantic City, I would type in *http://atlanticcity.com* into the search box of a WHOIS database and keep my fingers crossed.

Contact Forms

I avoid Contact forms usually because I know they get marked with some unique tag before going into someone's e-mail inbox, and that might unprioritize or de-value my e-mail before the person even reads it. (They may feel like they can procrastinate on it because it's usually advertising inquiries or PR mail they receive with that tag.)

A Word About Twitter

If you can't find someone's e-mail address, you can usually find them on Twitter. Don't try to close them instantly on Twitter; instead, Tweet @ them with a comment or question about a recent post they wrote, and if you get a reply back, say you'd like to inquire about something and ask them to DM you their e-mail address. **Make sure you're following them before you ask for a DM**.

First Contact

Before proceeding, you absolutely need to have a look at this wisdom by Ramit Sethi on I Will Teach You to be Rich. Although he doesn't know it (or me), I owe Ramit every single guest post I've written – without his advice as outlined in that post, my chances of success would've been **much** lower. Still haven't read the post? Do it **now**.

Remember: In **any** scenario, you are trying to **make the other party's life easier**. Don't do anything that would make it more difficult for them to complete a response to you. Remove as much friction as possible.

Here a few pieces to be sure to include in your first e-mail with an editor or administrator:

Subject: "Reader Inquiries + Guest Post Idea"

In any case that I've e-mailed a blogger, I typically get a warm response by including "Reader Inquiries" or "Reader Questions" in the subject line. Now, I'm not saying you should fake being a reader; rather, ***become a reader***. A great way to build rapport would be to ask a question that elaborates on the origins of one of their posts, or to ask why they did something they did.

Alternatively, sometimes I tell them which posts are my favourites and how these posts in particular have prompted me to write a guest post on their blog.

I'd like to reinforce this point: Don't be dishonest! Editors are not idiots. Seriously, create an opinion of their work and think of questions before e-mailing.

Anyway, as a blogger and writer myself, I find I love reading e-mails from my readers, especially if they want to find out more about something I wrote. It means they've read a bit of my writing and actually paid enough attention to consider it thoroughly. Truly, I appreciate that enough to take the time out of any day to reply. Similarly, most bloggers will be respectful enough to their readers to do the same. (Exceptions being bloggers too big to handle their current volume of e-mails.)

Where have You Written Before?

This is relatively self-evident: sure, you're a passionate reader, but so are 59,999 other people. Why should you get the opportunity to write for this blog?

At first, if you don't have any guest posts published anywhere else, you can link to blog posts you've written on your own blog. (Don't have one? Set it up **now** with WordPress. More on this later.) Try to find the ones with the most social media activity or reader discussion tied up to it.

It's important to include this because you're basically showing them (or proving to them) that you've got the chops and the hustle to write awesome articles, and you won't tarnish their reputation.

If you have any, link to other blogs or websites you've guest posted for (bonus points for higher-traffic blogs). This is a social proofing technique: If other people thought you were good enough to write for them, then you may be good enough to for this editor to trust her own blog's reputation with. (More incentive and reason why you

need to give away your best work!)

Who Are You?

Being a writer is a very personal thing, so it's important to include a small introduction to yourself and what your passions, interests, and fields of expertise are. Don't give your life story, two or three sentences should be enough to encompass this.

How did You First Stumble Across their Blog or Work?

This tactic helps to build the foundation for why you want to write for this particular blog (besides wanting more traffic). Did you receive excellent advice that first time? What changes in your life or perspective did that advice produce? Did you first come across their blog from another guest post that this particular author did?

Why do You Want to Write for Their Blog?

Are you passionate about this niche? Do you have something that you thought would be perfect for this blog? Why is it perfect for this blog in particular? Have you been a close reader of this blog?

You get the idea. This question, as well as the previous question, helps convey your passion for their blog and their niche. This also helps build rapport with the blogger: they've just met someone like-minded, and was interested enough in building a relationship that dedicated enough time to find their e-mail address and write-up a comprehensive cold e-mail. Fantastic.

A Few Detailed Point-Form Pitches

Make them easy to scan, but make them detailed. My points rarely last longer than a line, and link to sources, statistics, and expert opinions. I also come up with the best headline I can under my self-imposed deadlines.

A prerequisite to a good pitch is an original idea. Try to find concrete examples supporting the trend you are observing, or find actionable tips to whatever advice you are pushing. Also, do not attempt a list post initially. (I know, I did it with Quick Online Tips, but that was almost three years ago.) They make even the most patient readers groan in pain, so you don't want to know how a blogger (usually reading a ton of posts around the blogosphere, keep in mind) may react. Connect new ideas together, make your point clear, and support your post with real-world examples, analogies, or case studies.

Usually, I separate the beginning, body, and end of my pitches with a line break. This is just to make it seem less intimidating. The body will have the most points in it. Remember to include statistics (and link to the sources), and refer to them to explain why your blog post actually matters. (If you're not an expert, your opinion doesn't count. And even experts use statistics. But, if you read Ramit Sethi's post, you'd already know that by now.)

At the very least, you'll get a thanks and an acknowledgement of your hard work. That's useful, because it already helps your reputation with the blogger and you've got your foot in the door. If you don't get it right with the first three pitches, you can go back in a couple of months with three new pitches, and talk about what additional steps you've taken to improve as a writer. (There's no shame in this, I've had to do it myself.)

Collaboration

So you got a yes! Be happy, and write a draft of your post. Edit it once a day over three days (let it make a new impression on you every day), make sure you follow word limits and style restrictions, and e-mail it to the blogger completely done in whatever format is best (I've found .doc or .docx to be compatible pretty much with every blogger).

Note: I'm aware some guest bloggers go so far as to share an HTML file in notepad format, just so bloggers can simply copy and paste this code into their backend and click publish. While that's a good practise, if you got confused by this idea, leave it alone; most people are absolutely fine with .doc files.

Sample Pitch:

The Resurrection of Men's Magazines

- Despite rise and barrier-free entries to web: blogging, webmags, etc., some are still choosing print and growing successfully.

- PORT Magazine: Competing with GQ, Time, New York. http://port-magazine.com/2012/03/port-named-spd-47th-annual-awards-finalist-magazine-of-the-year/

- Enjoying good things: poetry, food, fashion. But not from a high horse at all. http://prote.in/profiles/dan-crowe

- Current magazines (like Esquire, GQ, Details)

- Compare to more classic look of PORT. http://www.selectism.com/news/2011/11/30/port-issue-4/#more-96914

- Similar growing "classical" pattern of magazines: Man About Town, Fantastic Man, AnOther Man.

- "It's not always famous people that are the interesting ones."

- Still compete digitally by almost fully replicating their magazines on iPads and tablets...and distributing for free.

- Less humor, more wit. http://vimeo.com/17368983 (Something reminiscent of Cracked?)

- Valuable as cultural authority, profound insight into the world today. (Same video as above.) Compare to frequently sponsored, flashy, and heavily advertised state of today's overwhelming magazines. (Esquire, GQ, Details.)

- Bring all the best elements of today's magazines back together into one classic package.

Scheduling

This is a business development tactic I borrowed from my friends: schedule your e-mails for anywhere around 7:40AM - 8:20AM, in the time zone of the editor. The weird thing about most people is they set time aside to read their e-mails first thing in the morning, so they are bound to open yours out of curiosity. The time that they budgeted for e-mails in the morning will make it more likely they take a few more minutes to finish reading your e-mail (as compared any other times throughout the rest of the day).

Alternatively, another good time to e-mail people is during their Sunday evening, when they want to get ahead on their week's work.

If you don't know how to schedule e-mails, check out Boomerang for Gmail and install it. It is gold.

Follow-Ups

Wow, follow-ups are **so** important. Another tactic I borrowed from my friends in biz dev: follow-up two or three days after your original e-mail (weekends don't count).

What's a follow-up look like?

Hey Enoch,

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Hope you're doing well! Just wanted to follow-up with this.

Sincerely,

Herbert
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Not even joking.

Your follow-up is simply meant to ping the other party, and re-divert their attention back to your original proposal. Often times, bloggers and editors are busy as hell. That means that one or two e-mails may slip their mind, so give them the benefit of the doubt. Plus, the psychological impulse for them to reciprocate to two unresponded e-mails tilts the likelihood of response in your favour. Good stuff.

Put your follow-ups in your calendar. So if you sent an e-mail to Jimmy Darmody on Monday, mark it down in your calendar on Wednesday and Friday to ping him. (Or Thursday and next Monday, if you want to be conservative.)

I originally hated follow-ups because I thought they'd be an intrusion to other people's time and attention. However, I learned from personal experience and from chatting with mentors and peers that follow-ups are generally quite accepted and will not be frowned upon.

There's a difference, though, between following up and spamming. The dividing line is drawn in frequency. Don't ping more than once every two days! Play it cool.

Introductions

Introductions rock because they make you instantly more credible. The party introducing you likely already has some pull with the editor you're want to be introduced to, so that already elevates your credibility to that editor.

I landed some of my best gigs through introductions.

It usually doesn't hurt to ask someone you know to make an introduction, just make sure you ask permission for an introduction first. "Hey Jimmy, would it be possible for you to introduce me to Nucky Thompson? I've got three guest post ideas that I think would be absolutely perfect for his media property."

That's a Mighty Lot of Research…

Most of the work required for a guest post is research. Roaming the Internet for someone's personal e-mail address, finding stats and quotes to incorporate in your posts, figuring out a particular blog's style and scope of coverage, examining which blogs would be suitable for you to target, amongst many other things.

At least some of the fog is cleared up for you now, so the only thing keeping you

from doing it is taking the first step. Then the next.

Here's what I've learned, from people I've interviewed and from my own experience: ***Hustle hard, and be consistent***. If you do these two things, you will have a good head start over the majority of the competition.

Why Would You Write for Free?!

I wasn't going to include a section like this, but I remember my friend once told me his writing professor told his class to never write for free. I was shocked.

These days, because of the barriers to publishing are being broken down, there are more journalists, writers, authors, and bloggers out there than ever before. Asking for a payment simply creates more friction for you as a writer, and can fudge your opportunity right up. Also, it's not exactly the most fantastic first step in a relationship, and can set a precedent for the relationship and the editor's perception of you as being very money-oriented.

In terms of reputation, very few people are going to know that you're not getting paid for your work.

You're buying something much more valuable by guest blogging or contributing to someone else's site for free: you're getting paid with credibility and the attention from the publications audience.

II. Un-shitty Content Ideas

There are a ton of articles out there that push out great advice on content creation. I refer to them for advice myself and I'd love to point some out to you:

- http://www.viperchill.com/create-viral-content/
- http://www.copyblogger.com/copywriting-benefits/
- http://www.contentmarketinginstitute.com/2012/06/content-we-crave/
- http://www.copyblogger.com/content-creativity-cleanse/
- http://raventools.com/blog/ultimate-list-of-online-content-readability-tests/

There's a lot to be taken from each of these posts. With that said, I'd like to highlight one particular type of post that may be effective for you.

The Power of Interviews

As author extraordinaire Malcolm Gladwell once pointed out, writing is largely a parasitic activity. As writers, we need something or somebody to write about. Gladwell's own books have a huge bibliography at the back, crediting the studies he cited and highlighting the people he has interviewed to find proof for his cases.

In my case, I'm a pretty young guy. While I'm not entirely inexperienced, I'm honest enough to admit that many other people have experienced more than I have. These experts' opinions are usually more valid than my own, due to these experts' close proximity to the battlefields of each of their niches.

That's why I don't choose to write my own opinion posts on trends and advice. Instead, I interview people. This allows me to borrow credibility from experts, by having their name tied to my article. It also allows me to tap into experiences that I have not yet had a chance to explore firsthand.

Additionally, interviewing someone means that they're likely to tap into their network and share the interview that you wrote about them. Everyone likes to share wisdom when it counts. If you make a good impression and write a good interview or profile, then the interviewee will likely pass it onto their friends, family, and clients, which translates into more pageviews and traffic for you and the publication you're writing for.

An interview can also be quite intimate; it is a 20 to 30 minute conversation between two people. This is great information-gathering time, if you use it properly; it is also a great chance to make a good first impression to someone who you think may matter later on in life.

It's almost like you're writing an article, but you've been equipped with two brains

and two lives instead of just one. You'll have the advantage of mixing your own perspective with the expert's opinions, and testing out your own hypotheses with the expert's.

Who to Interview?

What is the blog's niche? What is your field of expertise? Most importantly, ***what will your post be about?***

For example, I come from a technology and marketing background. If I was to do an interview for Hypebeast, I would likely choose someone leading a marketing campaign for a retail firm. If I was to do an interview for Techvibes, I would pick a Canadian entrepreneur disrupting an industry through technology, or a Canadian social media personality. This is when knowing your target blog comes in handy; who have they interviewed previously, or who does this editor look up to? Who would be perfect for this audience to learn from?

How to Get in Touch?

Similar to finding guest blogs to post at, find the e-mail addresses of people you want to interview. Similarly, contextualize how you first heard about them: was it a speech at a conference, or did you meet them somewhere else? Did you stumble on their work as a blogger?

Conferences

Conferences are cold e-mails on steroids for networking with interviewees. Often times, if you get invited to a conference by the organizer, or volunteer at the conference, you can ask if there's a possibility you could interview the keynote speakers. There's a very high chance that they'll say yes, and that it will be on that time and day of the conference, so show up prepared!

Your Value Proposition

You are offering two things: the attention of your readers (or the publications readers) and enhancing the expert's credibility. You are offering to further establish them as an expert and thought leader in their field of interest. Of course, pageviews are a very valuable metric for measuring success in traffic. You are also offering the networking benefits that you'd evaluated earlier for your own opportunities, such as having an interested investor come across this person's interview.

You don't need to explicitly state this in the e-mail you send a potential interviewee, just keep in mind that these are the things they're looking for should they choose to invest their time into you.

Positioning: You are the Avid Learner

Passion is contagious. People love passion. If you seem like you're eager and excited to learn more about their journey, their expertise, and their perspective on things, you will come out ahead of the other e-mails they receive. Your passion shines through in the research you put into your questions. Which brings me to...

Asking the Right Questions

I recently learned that Einstein said, "If I had an hour to save the world, I would spend 59 minutes coming up with the right question."

That's a very relevant statement for this topic of interviewing. Your job is simply to come up with questions. While it is simple, it is not usually too easy. You want to:

- Avoid questions that you can find on Page 1, 2, or 3 of a Google Search query with *their name + interview* in it.
- Elaborate on questions from previous interviews that may have interested you.
- If they're keynote speakers, look for their SlideShares and see if any of their slides intrigue you. Ask them about that.
- Make sure you know if there are any topics you should try to steer clear of.
- Constrain the questions appropriately; "What are the latest social media trends?" may be a bit more difficult to answer than, "I've heard this piece of news, what do you think this means for society?"

I have no doubt that in a few more months, I'll have come up with better types of questions. Try new ones, and test how your interviewees react to them. Some may stump them (for better or worse). Some may confuse them. Mark this down and tweak the question a bit, then try out a different way to phrase that question.

Taping and Transcribing

I usually prefer to do face-to-face interviews, but I can't afford to travel over the world just for a 30 minute conversation with interesting people. (That would be a fun goal for the future.)

In this case, I've had to use my handy-dandy cell phone on speaker and my voice recorder. If it's possible, I actually try to have a conversation over Skype instead, just because some phones interfere with tape recorders as they're recording.

With every interview, I always bring my notebook to record key points, phrases, themes, and ideas in. I recognize how vulnerable technology is to damage or failure,

and I never put all my eggs in that basket.

E-mail Interviews

They rarely work out. This is just because e-mails can take quite a while longer for an interviewee to type out, and because you may forget to follow-up with them and they have more to worry about than an interview they promised another writer. I've had one entrepreneur reply with a very comprehensive e-mail interview, which was fantastic; this meant that direct quotes got a lot easier for that post.

Summarizing

A 15-minute conversation can convert into 2,000 words. My editors kindly told me to chop it down into a shorter piece, just because people have short attention spans for articles these days.

What I ended up doing was combining the interview into a trend piece, creating a hybrid profile-esque piece. I grouped segments of the interview according to key ideas, and then selected quotes that were the most powerful to each key idea. That cut things down by quite a bit, and also allowed me to explore more research online after the initial conversation.

When in Doubt, Launch

Entrepreneurs have a saying: If you're not embarrassed by it, you're not launching soon enough. Now, I know writing can be very personal, but it's extremely important to meet your own deadlines in order to keep pushing out a steady volume of guest posts.

What artist isn't overcritical of his own work? Don't get caught up in your own opinion of a piece. When your post hits a deadline, e-mail it to the editor and launch.

III. Evaluating Opportunities

We only have a limited trove of energy and time everyday, so how do we pick the best opportunities?

There are countless articles that expand on something known as the 80-20 rule, or the Pareto Principle: Basically, 20% of your efforts will produce 80% of your results. How do you know which 20% of your efforts are producing 80% of your results? That way, you can create a situation where (theoretically) you are achieving a lot more with the same amount of effort you put in.

Blogger and media personality Amber Mac once told me to follow three criteria when taking opportunities into consideration:

1. Financial Goals

This isn't so much a guest posting goal (as guest posting is done for free), but more so for becoming a regular contributor for a blog or publication, which guest blogging can naturally progress into if an editor or blogger thinks your work is valuable.

Will collaborating with this party pay off financially? How much closer to your target does it bring you? This is an obvious one, and most people only consider finances when they're measuring their return. However, there are two other pretty important factors to consider...

2. Time

Do you have time and energy to do a good job?

Remember, you are only as good as your last piece of work; make sure it is your best effort.

3. Opportunity

For writers, opportunity can come in the form of:

- Education: You really wanted to learn from this person about their experience in their industry
- Reach: How many people unfamiliar with your work will be reading this guest post of yours?
- Credibility: Will this opportunity make other opportunities in the future more attainable?

- Networking: Will you be in contact with potential new clients for your business, potential mentors and employers if they can see you're a thought leader, or potential strategic partners or investors if you are an entrepreneur?

Think of opportunity in terms of value in different forms. Only you can decide how much value something is worthy of; don't get too hung up trying to figure minor differences out.

This is relatively straightforward. My only advice here would be to focus: don't go where everyone is herding to (usually the new social network, or the list posts). Instead, find a few things that you want to be good at, and discipline yourself so that you don't have an option to procrastinate and distract yourself on other social networks to keep busy and avoid work.

Seth Godin doesn't use Twitter. He has spent 10 years persistently building up his Typepad blog, and has stuck with it through the introduction of WordPress and Tumblr. His focus on writing and his deliberate avoidance of social media trends has been a prerequisite to helping him achieve the success he has as an author and entrepreneur. (Ever heard of The Icarus Deception? Undoubtedly one of the most successful non-tech Kickstarter campaigns I've set eyes upon.)

There's no shortage of opportunity. Capitalize on a few of yours and make the most of them.

IV. Getting More Done with Batch Processing

I first picked this up from ProBlogger Darren Rowse, who introduced the idea of batch processing to his readers. I once went through a similar point when I was forced to process in batches, just because I went without internet for a few weeks. Whenever I wanted to use the internet, I'd have to run over to a cafe. That meant time setting up and travelling, so I'd make sure to compress all my tasks into one session.

This turned out super effective.

Basically, I would have to write 2-3 first drafts of blog posts before I could leave the cafe. While this sounds fun, it really isn't; I love cafes, but they don't scream exciting when I take them in for 3-4 hours at a time. Even though I didn't initially enjoy it, I had never experienced that level of productivity before.

Parkinson's Law states that "Work expands to fill the time available for its completion." Batch processing forces us to meet a deadline we set for ourselves (we need to get this, this, and that done within two hours). It squeezes the extra time out of Parkinson's Law.

Additionally, it could be just the mental reinforcement of motivation, as well as a natural mental setup time; in any case, batch processing makes people more effective. It has worked for me and Darren, and tons of other individuals.

Since guest blogging will require a ton of research, you will need every spare moment you can get your hands on. Try out batch processing.

V. Can you Even Write?

How do you prove to the places you want to get featured that you are an intelligent, experienced, and relevant writer?

You show them your writing.

If you've written for other blogs before, fantastic. However, there's an issue of control and freedom with other blogs: your name may not be next to your post forever. It could be because of a change in editorial policy, or a messy departure, or a variety of other reasons. Maybe that blog or website decides to shut down.

What's the solution?

You need your own property on the web, somewhere that is an aggregate of all our work collectively. A WordPress.org blog works well as a solution:

- You can install your blog on a hosted server, and WordPress is free. As long as you pay for your server, you will have a space on the web. You can also back up your WordPress archives regularly, which means even if your host becomes unavailable for whatever reason, you will have your database stored on your hard drive and can re-upload it to a new WordPress installation with a new host.
- It's easy to set up. One-click.
- You can start right away. I guarantee you if you choose to install WordPress tonight, you will be able to finish a post by tonight.
- You can expand on WordPress to build other features in, like Lightbox and membership communities.

My Writer's Craft teacher (what's good, Mr. Leznoff?) drilled into us his mantra: "Show, don't tell." I totally agree. Things are so much more powerful when the audience sees for themselves what is happening, and can make a judgment on their own. So the idea is to show the editor of the magazine or blog you want to write for that you are a great writer, instead of just telling them. Ideally, they will see that as soon as they start browsing through your work with your blog.

Make sure you are proud of every single piece you do!

Before you start sending people towards your blog, you may want to build what Ramit Sethi calls a Catcher's Mitt: Basically, a collection of posts that will entice a new reader to stay on your blog.

A basic prerequisite would be 15-20 timeless (never outdated) posts that new readers can stumble upon and be attracted to in an instant.

Closing

If you've gotten this far, either you skipped ahead or you've finished the book. Shame on you if it's the former, and congratulations if it's the latter.

Here are some steps to you to take by the end of the night:

- Make a list of three magazines or blogs you want to be featured on. (Est: 1 minute)
- Find out who the editors are of these magazines or blogs. Find out their e-mail addresses. (Est. 10 minutes)
- Complete one pitch for one of these blogs. (Est. 30 minutes)

41 minutes is a small price to pay to start building the momentum you need to get this show on the road. Best of luck, and let me know if I can ever help you with anything.

Let's Connect!

If you enjoyed this eBook, or if it helps you in any way, please shoot me an e-mail! You can reach me at Herbert.hb.lui (at) gmail (dot) com. You can also holler at me on Twitter (@herbertlui). Alternatively, you can stalk me at www.herbertlui.ca; don't do that though, that's no fun.

I promise to read and respond to your e-mail! And if I don't, just follow up ;-)

Fin.

Acknowledgements

First and foremost, I need to thank moms and pops for being supportive of my explorations into writing, and for bearing with the juvenile nicknames I give them. Thank you for your patience, for pushing me out of my comfort zone, and for the confidence you've put in me.

Lots of thanks and respect to Rob Lewis, Knowlton Thomas, and Dan Verhaeghe at Techvibes. Rob and Knowlton, thanks for taking the chance on me and the guidance you've shared. Dan, thanks for the introduction and the advice.

Big ups to Jay Song at Kinowear for publishing my first self-development piece and for the words of wisdom he was kind enough to share on a blog that I've been following for so long. This was when I truly realized the possibilities of getting published anywhere.

I tip my hat to Erin Bury at BetaKit and Renee Warren at Onboardly for both your support. Thanks for the guidance and advice while I was a social media newb, Renee. And thanks for giving me a shot at tackling Trends, Erin.

Thanks to Eugene Kan, Alex Maeland, and Ambrose Leung from Hypebeast for bearing with my persistent follow-ups and for daring to expose me to the hypebeasts out there. Luckily, I didn't make any of us look too bad (yet). Heh.

TBIP, thanks for welcoming me into your tribe of elites. Vino, Jon, Dami, Vijay, Mel, Nick, it has been a blast getting to know you and watching you folks crush it.

Last, but most certainly not least, what's good, my amigos? Pete, Steve, Char, Keane, Josh, Grace, Nick, Dhruv, Rohan, Farhan, Aaron, Cam, Matt. Thanks for believing in me and for pushing my work to the next level.